

THE UNIVERSAL HOUSE OF JUSTICE

2001-01-09

To the conference of the continental boards of cou

1 dearly loved friends,

five years ago, we called on the body of counselors assembled in the

2 holy land to aid the bahá'í world to understand and shoulder the chal-
3 lenges of systematic growth. The brilliant achievements of the four year
4 plan testify to the wholehearted response they made. Today, we ask for an
5 equally great effort on your part, this time to ensure the successful launching
6 of the five year plan.

7 in your deliberations on the nature of this next stage in the unfoldment
8 of the divine plan, you need to take into account the magnitude of the
9 changes occurring in the fortunes of the faith. At the world center, the
10 raising of the great edifices now standing on the Arc represents a major
11 step in the consolidation of a divinely appointed Administrative order. The
12 four year plan witnessed a remarkable increase in the institutional capacity
13 of bahá'í communities in every continent. The evolution of National and
14 local Spiritual Assemblies has visibly accelerated, and regional councils,
15 where they have been established, have brought a new energy and effective-
16 ness to the work of the cause. with the birth and efflorescence of more
17 than 300 training institutes, the faith now possesses a powerful instrument
18 for developing the human resources needed to sustain large-scale expan-
19 sion and consolidation. further, the ability of the bahá'í community to
20 influence the course of human affairs, both through its dealings with gov-
21 ernments and organizations of civil society and through its endeavors in

social and economic development, has been greatly enhanced. The cause

22 of bahá'u'lláh stands at the threshold of a new epoch, at a moment in his-

23 tory when, despite confusion and outbursts of fresh hostility, the world has
24 made real strides towards peace. one clearly sees an increasing receptivity to
25 his all-pervasive and resplendent Spirit.

Advancing the process of entry by troops will continue as the aim of

26 the five year plan—indeed the aim of the series of plans that will carry
27 the community to the end of the first century of the formative Age. The
28 acceleration of this vital process will be achieved through systematic activity 348.1

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349 2000–2001 • The Twelfth Plan

350 76on the part of the three participants in the plan: the individual believer, the
351 institutions, and the community.

The Training Institute

352 A searching analysis of the four year plan recently prepared for us by
353 the international Teaching center demonstrates that the training institute
354 is effective not only in enhancing the powers of the individual, but also
355 in vitalizing communities and institutions. The continued development of training
institutes in the diverse countries and territories of the world, then, must be a central feature
of the new plan.

drawing on the wealth of experience now accumulated in this area of

356 endeavor, institutes will have to provide their communities with a constant stream of
human resources to serve the process of entry by troops. elements

357 of a system that can meet the training needs of large numbers of believers have
already been tested worldwide and have proven themselves. Study circles, reinforced by
extension courses and special campaigns, have shown their ability to lend structure to the
process of spiritual education at the grassroots.

358 The value of a sequence of courses, each one following the other in a logical
359 pattern and each one building on the achievements of the previous ones, has become
abundantly clear. various models are emerging that provide insight

360 into how such sequences can be used to create training programs. in one

361 example the main sequence, much like the trunk of a tree, supports courses branching
out from it, each branch dedicated to some specific area of training. in another, several
tracks of courses, each with its own focus, run parallel.

362 institutes will do well to examine these elements and approaches and employ

363 them in a manner that responds to the opportunities before them.

At the outset of the Twelve month plan we underscored the need for

364 bahá'í children to be nurtured spiritually and to be integrated into the life
365 of the cause. There is every indication from the response of the friends
366 thus far that a raised awareness of the importance of child education will, in fact, be a
hallmark of this brief yet significant plan. A new impetus has
367 been given to bahá'í children's classes. increased awareness has also brought
368 to light opportunities to offer moral and spiritual education to children in general, as
exemplified by the success of the efforts to introduce courses on the bahá'í faith into
programs of official school systems.

That institutes are placing more and more emphasis on the training of

369 teachers for children's classes is a particularly encouraging sign. other mea-348.4
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349 meS Sa ge S f ro m Th e u n i v e r S a l h o u S e o f j u S T i c e
350 76sures are equally essential if regular classes for every age are to be offered
351 in bahá'í communities throughout the world. in some countries, national
352 and regional committees have been established to assist local Spiritual
353 Assemblies in the discharge of their responsibility to educate children. in
354 these, the relationship between the committees and the training institute will steadily
evolve as experience is gained, each agency enhancing the work
355 of the other. but there are many countries in which the institute is the
356 only structure developing the capacity to organize and maintain courses
357 in locality after locality. As this approach is working well with youth and adults, and
increasingly for junior youth, there is no reason why the train-
358 ing institute should not also shoulder similar responsibility with respect
359 to children, where necessary. As a general rule, institutes do not take on the
administration of plans and programs for expansion and consolidation.
360 conducting children's classes, however, is a unique enterprise, of special
361 urgency. in those countries where the task is given to it, the institute be-
362 comes a center of learning intensely engaged in the spiritual education of the friends
from the tenderest age through adulthood.

Individual Initiative in Teaching

363 with the work of institutes growing in strength, attention has now to be
364 given everywhere to systematizing teaching efforts. in the document “The
365 institution of the counselors” just issued, we emphasize the role that the
366 Auxiliary board members and their assistants play in helping the friends to
367 meet this challenge, both at the level of individual initiative and of collective
368 volition. As individuals progress through institute courses, they deepen their
369 knowledge of the faith, gain insights, and acquire skills of service. Some of
370 the courses devoted to teaching will no doubt treat the subject in general terms.
others will focus on various means of sharing bahá’u’lláh’s message

371 with specific segments of society, incorporating the wisdom gleaned from the
teaching endeavors of the friends. This combined process of action, learning and training
will endow communities with an ever-increasing num-ber of capable and eager teachers of
the cause.

372 T raining alone, of course, does not necessarily lead to an upsurge in
373 teaching activity.

374 in every avenue of service, the friends need sustained encouragement.

375 our expectation is that the Auxiliary board members, together with their

376 assistants, will give special thought to how individual initiative can be cul-tivated,
particularly as it relates to teaching. when training and encourage-348.8

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349 2000–2001 • T h e T W e l v e m o n Th Pl a n

350 765ment are effective, a culture of growth is nourished in which the believers see
351 their duty to teach as a natural consequence of having accepted bahá’u’lláh.

352 They “raise high the sacred torch of faith,” as was ‘Abdu’l-b ahá’s wish, “la-

353 bor ceaselessly, by day and by night,” and “consecrate every fleeting moment of their
lives to the diffusion of the divine fragrance and the exaltation of god’s holy word.”

354 348-1 So enkindled do their hearts become with the fire

355 of the love of god that whoever approaches them feels its warmth. They

356 strive to be channels of the spirit, pure of heart, selfless and humble, pos-sessing
certitude and the courage that stems from reliance on god. in such

357 a culture, teaching is the dominating passion of the lives of the believers.

358 fear of failure finds no place. mutual support, commitment to learning,
359 and appreciation of diversity of action are the prevailing norms.

Systematic Programs of Growth

360 during the coming months, you will be helping national communities,
361 whose circumstances differ widely, to formulate plans for systematic growth.

362 There are many countries where increased institutional capacity, particu-
363 larly at the level of the region, now makes it possible to focus attention on
364 smaller geographic areas. most of these will consist of a cluster of villages
365 and towns, but, sometimes, a large city and its suburbs may constitute an area of this
kind. Among the factors that determine the boundaries of a

366 cluster are culture, language, patterns of transport, infrastructure, and the
367 social and economic life of the inhabitants. The areas into which a region divides will
fall into various categories of development. Some will not yet be open to the faith, while
others will contain a few isolated localities and

368 groups; in some, established communities will be gaining strength through a
vigorous institute process; in a few, strong communities of deepened believ-ers will be in a
position to take on the challenges of systematic and acceler-
369 ated expansion and consolidation.

370 once the appropriate categories have been identified, national plans in
371 these countries will need to make provision for the progressive opening of
372 virgin areas through the settlement of homefront pioneers. Such goals can
373 be met with relative ease if pioneers are experienced in institute programs
374 and are able to use their methods and materials in raising up a group of dedicated
believers who can carry the work of the faith forward in the area.

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349 m e S Sa g e S f r o m T h e u n i v e r S a l h o u S e o f j u S T i c e

350 766precious indeed will be the privilege of those who, in the remaining years
351 of the first century of the formative Age, place their trust in god and arise
352 with fervor to take the lead in carrying the light of divine guidance to every
353 part of their countries. it is our hope that this call for homefront pioneers
354 will generate great enthusiasm among the friends and open before their eyes
355 a new vista of possibilities to serve the f aith.

356 According to this scheme, national plans will also need to include provi-
357 sion for the strengthening of other areas which, although open to the faith,
358 have yet to reach the level of development that prepares them for intensive activity.
in those areas where strong communities with a corps of deepened
359 believers exist, systematic programs for the expansion and consolidation of the faith
should be established forthwith. we have already indicated that
360 the international Teaching center has identified certain patterns of growth
361 appropriate for relatively small geographical areas. Since then, it has ana-lyzed
several pilot projects in various parts of the world, and its findings are highly encouraging.
The lessons learned now provide a body of experience for the launching of programs for
systematic growth in area after area. As
362 you consult on this matter with National Spiritual Assemblies and regional
363 councils, you will want to keep the Teaching center informed.
364 it is important that national communities not rush into establishing inten-
365 sive programs in an area before conditions are propitious. These conditions include: a
high level of enthusiasm among a sizeable group of devoted and
366 capable believers who understand the prerequisites for sustainable growth and can
take ownership of the program; some basic experience on the
367 part of a few communities in the cluster in holding classes for the spiritual
368 education of children, devotional meetings, and the Nineteen day feast;
369 the existence of a reasonable degree of administrative capacity in at least a few local
Spiritual Assemblies; the active involvement of several assistants

to Auxiliary board members in promoting community life; a pronounced

370 spirit of collaboration among the various institutions working in the area; and above
all, the strong presence of the training institute with a scheme of coordination that supports
the systematic multiplication of study circles.

programs initiated in such areas should aim at fostering sustainable

371 growth by building the necessary capacity at the levels of the individual, the
institution, and the community. far from requiring grandiose and elaborate
372 plans, these programs should focus on a few measures that have proven over the
years to be indispensable to large-scale expansion and consolidation. Success will depend on
the manner in which lines of action are integrated 348.13

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349 2000–2001 • T h e T W e l v e m o n Th P l a n

350 767and on the attitude of learning that is adopted. The implementation of such
351 a program will require the close collaboration of the institute, the Auxiliary
352 board members and their assistants, and an Area Teaching committee.

353 At the core of the program must lie a sound and steady process of expan-
354 sion, matched by an equally strong process of human resource development.

355 A range of teaching efforts needs to be carried out, involving both activities
356 undertaken by the individual and campaigns promoted by the institutions.

357 As the number of believers in the area rises, a significant percentage should receive
training from the institute, and their capabilities be directed towards the development of
local communities.

our message of 26 december 1995 delineating the features of the four

358 year plan made reference to the stages through which a community passes
359 as it develops. The experience that has been gained in the ensuing years in
360 working with communities at various stages will prove valuable to programs
361 of growth. one of the first steps in implementing the program may well
362 be a survey to determine the condition of each locality in the area. Among the initial
goals for every community should be the establishment of study
363 circles, children's classes, and devotional meetings, open to all the inhabit-
364 ants of the locality. The observance of the Nineteen day feast has to be
365 given due weight, and consistent effort should be made to strengthen the local
Spiritual Assemblies. once communities are able to sustain the basic
366 activities of bahá'í life, a natural way to further their consolidation is to in-
367 troduce small projects of social and economic development—for example, a literacy
project, a project for the advancement of women or environmental
368 preservation, or even a village school. As strength builds, the responsibility
369 for an increasing number of lines of action is to be devolved onto the local
370 Spiritual Assemblies.

371 Throughout the endeavor, periodic meetings of consultation in the area
372 need to reflect on issues, consider adjustments, and maintain enthusiasm and unity of
thought. The best approach is to formulate plans for a few months at a time, beginning with
one or two lines of action and gradu-ally growing in complexity. Those who are actively
involved in the imple-
373 mentation of plans, whether members of the institutions or not, should

374 be encouraged to participate fully in the consultations. other area-wide
375 gatherings will also be necessary. Some of these will provide opportunity
376 for the sharing of experience and further training. others will focus on the
377 use of the arts and the enrichment of culture. Together, such gatherings will
378 support an intense process of action, consultation and learning.348.16

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349 m e S a g e S f r o m T h e u n i v e r S a l h o u S e o f j u S T i c e

350 768The friends who participate in these intensive programs of growth should
351 bear in mind that the purpose is to ensure that the revelation of bahá'u'lláh
352 reaches the masses of humanity and enables them to achieve spiritual and
353 material progress through the application of the Teachings. vast numbers
354 among the peoples of the world are ready, indeed yearn, for the bounties that
bahá'u'lláh alone can bestow upon them once they have committed
355 themselves to building the new society he has envisioned. in learning to
356 systematize their large-scale teaching work, bahá'í communities are becom-
357 ing better equipped to respond to this longing. They cannot withhold what-ever
effort, whatever sacrifice, may be called for.

A Spiritual Enterprise

358 clearly, the scheme described here, while suitable to many national com-
359 munities, cannot be applied in every situation. we count on the ability
360 of the bahá'í institutions to create plans which, if not reflecting the total
361 scheme above, will incorporate elements of its vision, according to the cir-
362 cumstances of each national community. bahá'í communities are, of course,
363 engaged in a range of indispensable endeavors such as public information activity,
proclamation efforts, external affairs work, production of literature, and complex social and
economic development projects. most certainly, as
364 plans are devised, they will also address these challenges.

The nature of the planning process with which you will be helping the

365 friends is in many ways unique. At its core it is a spiritual process in which
communities and institutions strive to align their pursuits with the will of
366 god. The major plan of god is at work and the forces it generates impel

367 humanity towards its destiny. in their own plans of action, the institutions
368 of the faith must seek to gain insight into the operation of these great
369 forces, explore the potentialities of the people they serve, measure the re-
370 sources and strengths of their communities, and take practical steps to enlist
371 the unreserved participation of the believers. The nurturing of this process is the
sacred mission entrusted to you. we have every confidence in your
372 ability to achieve it. may bahá'u'lláh bless and sustain you through his
373 unfailing grace and mighty confirmations.

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The Institution of the Counselors

[signed: The Universal House of Justice]